



Hattusas, the Hittite capital, was founded by Hattusalis I in 1650 BCE and destroyed in 1180 BCE.

AFTER HAMMURABI'S DEATH in 1750 BCE, the Babylonian Empire (see 1850–1790 BCE) declined. At the same time, other powers were on the rise, such as the **Hurrians** of Mitanni in Syria, and the **Hittites** of Anatolia in Turkey. By 1650 BCE, the Hittites had built an extensive kingdom in central Anatolia, with its capital at Hattusas. The Hittites had developed advanced bronze- and **ironworking** skills, and they were also known to be **fierce fighters**. In 1595 BCE, the Hittite king **Mursilis** (r. 1620–1590 BCE) **raided Babylon** and expanded his empire. However, he was killed soon after, and the empire shrank back for about a century.

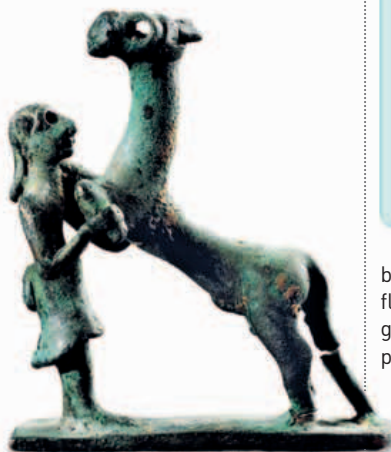
In Egypt, the **Middle Kingdom** (see 2000–1850 BCE) was **waning**



IRON-WORKING

The Hittites developed iron smelting by c. 1500 BCE. At first, iron was used only in luxury objects, such as in the decoration of this box from Acemhoyek. Later, as technology developed, iron was used to create superior weapons. Though the Hittites traded iron goods, they kept this technology secret for about 300 years. Around 1200 BCE, ironworking spread to Greece, and then to Central Europe by c. 750 BCE—the dawn of the Iron Age.

by 1670 BCE, partly due to erratic floods in the Nile. As regional governors became more powerful, **civil war** broke out. Outsiders soon took advantage of the unrest. The **Nubians** won back lands that the Egyptians had taken earlier (see 2000–1850 BCE). In 1650 BCE, the **Hyksos** from the Levant seized Lower Egypt, but Upper Egypt remained under the control of Egyptian kings.



Man and beast

The Hittite Empire was known for its bronze craftsmanship. Bronze weapons and artifacts fetched a high price. This statuette of a man and a horse was probably a commission.



Built over 300 years, the temple complex at Karnak, Egypt, includes the world's largest temple, dedicated to Amun-Re, the patron deity of the pharaohs.

IN c. 1550 BCE, THE THEBAN KING Ahmose I (r. 1550–1525 BCE) **drove the Hyksos** from Lower Egypt, ushering in the third period of settled rule in Egypt, known as the **New Kingdom** (c. 1550–1070 BCE). During this time, **Egyptian rulers** assumed

Egyptian religion was very complex. Every village, town, and district had its own patron deity. In paintings and sculptures, many deities were shown with animal heads, representing their most important attributes. For example, the falcon god Horus protected the king, while the ibis-headed Thoth was the patron god of scribes.

By 1600 BCE, a new civilization emerged

on the Greek mainland. Its people are now known as the **Mycenaeans**, after the fortress-palace of Mycenae, believed to be the home of the mythical king Agamemnon from Homer's *Iliad*. However, the Mycenaeans

2000

THE NUMBER OF NAMES FOR GODS AND GODDESSES IN ANCIENT EGYPT

the title "**pharaoh**," meaning "great house." A succession of warrior kings campaigned to expand Egypt's boundaries once more. **Tuthmosis I** (r. 1504–1492 BCE) **drove the Nubians** back in the south and recaptured Sinai and parts of Syria and Palestine. Under **Tuthmosis III** (r. 1479–1425 BCE), Egypt controlled a strip along the Mediterranean coast and north of the Euphrates (see p.33).

The conquered states paid huge annual tributes to Egypt, a part of which was spent building one of the world's largest **religious sites at Karnak** and the impressive mortuary temple of **Queen Hatshepsut** (r. 1473–1458 BCE).



Mask of gold

German archaeologist Heinrich Schliemann found this funerary mask at a grave in Mycenae, and claimed it belonged to King Agamemnon.

